

Pre Marital Sex And Cohabitation

prc-pre-marital-sex-and-cohabitation

Marriage & Sexuality · Sexual Ethics · doctrine · unanimous_lineages

AFFIRMS

Supported across the whole Bible
Subject named directly in
Scripture
Holds across manuscript variants

Statement under examination

Sexual intimacy is reserved for marriage between one man and one woman; pre-marital sex (fornication) and unmarried cohabitation that includes sexual relations are sin.

In plain language

Two lexical pillars carry this question. The first is the Greek word 'sexual immorality' (porneia), which appears 26 times in the New Testament as the broad term for illicit sexual intercourse. In 1 Corinthians 6:18 the command is to flee 'sexual immorality' (porneia), and the one who commits it is said to sin against his own body, using the verb 'sins' (hamartanei). In 1 Thessalonians 4:3 God's will, called sanctification, is to abstain from 'sexual immorality' (porneia). In Ephesians 5:3 'sexual immorality' (porneia) and all impurity must not even be named among the saints. Hebrews 13:4 lists 'sexually immoral persons' (pornous) separately from 'adulterers' (moichous), so 'sexual immorality' (porneia) is not narrowed to married people straying. Its Old Testament cognate, the Hebrew 'to be sexually immoral or play the harlot' (zanah), appears 91 times, and Deuteronomy 22:20-21 uses it for sexual relations by an unmarried woman before marriage, treating the absence of 'virginity-tokens' (betulim) as a punishable wrong. The second pillar is positive. Genesis 2:24 says a man leaves father and mother, cleaves, that is, clings tightly to (davaq), his wife, and the two become one flesh ('one flesh', basar echad). That clause is cited three times in the New Testament, by Jesus at Matthew 19:5, by Paul at 1 Corinthians 6:16 (where joining to a prostitute is wrong because it misplaces the one-flesh bond), and by Paul at Ephesians 5:31. Hebrews 13:4 puts the same point as a standing: marriage (gamos) is honorable and the bed (he koite) is undefiled (amiantos), bounded by marriage itself. 1 Corinthians 7:2 names a man's own wife and a woman's own husband as the remedy for porneia. Where readers diverge, it tends to be over the exact width of porneia or whether the Old Testament case law in Exodus 22:16 and Deuteronomy 22:28 treats unmarried sex as a wrong remedied by marriage or as constituting marriage. Even on the narrower readings, the words still locate sexual union inside the husband-wife pair and treat sexual activity outside it as a sexual offense.

Word dictionary

Every Hebrew and Greek word this study leans on, in everyday terms. Shaded rows are the anchor words the verdict rests on.

Strong	Word	Sounds like	Plain meaning	Times in Bible
H0259	אחד	echad	one	
H1320	בשר	basar	flesh	250
H1331	בתולים	betulim	virginity	10
H1692	דבק	davaq	to cleave	46
H2181	זנה	zanah	to fornicate	91
H5003	נאף	naaph	to commit adultery	
G0038	ἁγιασμός	hagiasmos	holiness	10

G0167	ἀκαθαρσία	akatharsia	impurity	10
G0265	ἁμάρτημα	hamartema	sin	5
G0283	ἀμίαντος	amiantos	pure	4
G1060	γαμέω	gameo	to marry	28
G1062	γάμος	gamos	wedding	16
G1392	δοξάζω	doxazō	to glorify	
G1484	ἔθνος	ethnos	Gentiles	
G1939	ἐπιθυμία	epithymia	desire	38
G2192	ἔχω	echō	to have/be	
G2398	ἴδιος	idios	one's own/private	
G2845	κοίτη	koite	bed	4
G2853	κολλάομαι	kollaomai	to join	12
G3431	μοιχεύω	moicheuō	to commit adultery	
G3432	μοιχός	moichos	adulterer	4
G4202	πορνεία	porneia	sexual sin	26
G4203	πορνεύω	porneuo	to sin sexually	8
G4204	πόρνη	porne	prostitute	12
G4205	πόρνος	pornos	sexual sinner	10
G4347	προσκολλάω	proskollaō	to join	
G4561	σάρξ	sarx	flesh	
G4632	σκεῦος	skeuos	vessel	
G4983	σῶμα	soma	body	144
G5092	τιμή	timē	honor	

Plain meanings: STEP Bible brief lexicons TBESH (Hebrew) and TBESG (Greek), CC BY 4.0. Counts are occurrences across the 66-book canon.

Verdict rationale

Variant-robust: True · Pan-canonical: True

The lexical engine has two reinforcing parts. Positive: Genesis 2:24 builds the cleaving and one-flesh formula from 'cleave or cling' (davaq, H1692) plus 'flesh' (basar, H1320) plus 'one' (echad, H0259), and that exact formula is quoted at Matthew 19:5, 1 Corinthians 6:16, and Ephesians 5:31, locating one-flesh union inside the man-and-wife pair. Hebrews 13:4 sets the standing as 'honored is the marriage in all and the bed undefiled' (timios ho gamos en pasin kai he koite amiantos) (G1062, G2845, G0283), the marriage bed alone honored and undefiled. Negative: 'sexual immorality' (porneia) (G4202, 26 occurrences in the New Testament) is the broad lexical category for illicit sexual intercourse and is the explicit object of prohibition (1 Corinthians 6:18 'flee sexual immorality' (pneugete ten porneian), 1 Thessalonians 4:3 'to abstain from sexual immorality' (apechesthai apo tes porneias), Ephesians 5:3 'let it not even be named' (mede onomazestho)), with the verb form 'to commit sexual immorality' (porneuo, G4203), the noun 'sexually immoral man' (pornos, G4205), and the noun 'prostitute or sexually immoral woman' (porne, G4204). Hebrews 13:4 names 'sexually immoral persons' (pornous) separately from 'adulterers' (moichous, G3432), so 'sexual immorality' (porneia) is not narrowed to adultery. The Old Testament cognate 'to be sexually immoral or play the harlot' (zanah, H2181, 91 occurrences) plus the 'virginity-tokens' (betulim) case in Deuteronomy 22:14, 20-21 plus the seduction case in Exodus 22:16 give an unbroken Old Testament to New Testament pattern that brackets sexual relations inside marriage and labels intercourse outside it as wrong.

Scripture

Gen.2.24 · for · genre: narrative

Key terms. H1692 דָּבַק; H1320 בָּשָׂר; H0259 אֶחָד

Reasoning. The foundational clause says a man leaves father and mother, cleaves, that is, clings tightly to (davaq, H1692), his wife, and the two become one flesh ('one flesh', basar echad, H1320 plus H0259). The verb 'cleave or cling' (davaq) paired with 'one flesh' (basar echad) makes the one-flesh union an attribute of the husband-wife pair specifically, not of any sexual partnership. Matthew 19:5, 1 Corinthians 6:16, and Ephesians 5:31 cite this verse with 'be joined' (kollaomai) and 'be joined to or glued onto' (proskollao) plus 'flesh' (sarx), transferring the same boundary into the New Testament.

Deut.22.20 · for · genre: law

Key terms. H1331 בְּתוּלִים; H2181 זָנָה

Reasoning. Deuteronomy 22:20-21 makes the absence of 'virginity-tokens' (betulim, H1331) at marriage prosecutable, and characterizes the act as 'to be sexually immoral or play the harlot' (zanah, H2181, to act as a prostitute or commit sexual immorality) committed in the father's house before marriage. The case law therefore explicitly classes premarital sex by an unmarried woman as 'sexual immorality' (zanah), the Old Testament cognate of 'sexual immorality' (porneia).

Heb.13.4 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G1062 γάμος, G2845 κοίτη, G0283 ἀμίαντος, G4205 πόρνος, G3432 μοιχός

Reasoning. 'Honored is the marriage in all and the bed undefiled, for the sexually immoral and adulterers God will judge' (Timios ho gamos en pasin kai he koite amiantos, pornous gar kai moichous krinei ho theos). Marriage ('marriage', gamos) is honorable and the bed ('bed', koite) undefiled ('undefiled', amiantos), bounded by 'marriage' (gamos) itself, and God will judge 'sexually immoral persons' (pornous) and 'adulterers' (moichous). Listing 'sexually immoral persons' (pornous) separately from 'adulterers' (moichous) lexically distinguishes sexual immorality (including non-adulterous fornication, that is, sexual sin not involving a married person) from adultery, so 'sexual immorality' (porneia) is not narrowed to adultery alone.

1Cor.6.16 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G2853 κολλάομαι, G4204 πόρνη, G4983 σῶμα

Reasoning. 'The one being joined to a prostitute is one body with her' (Ho kollomenos te porne hen soma estin). Paul cites Genesis 2:24, 'for the two, he says, will be one flesh' (esontai gar phesin hoi duo eis sarka mian), to argue that joining to a 'prostitute or sexually immoral woman' (porne, a sexual partner outside marriage) creates the one-flesh bond, but in the wrong place. The argument only works if one-flesh union is by lexical definition the husband-wife bond, so sexual joining outside marriage misuses the union.

1Cor.6.18 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G4202 πορνεία, G4203 πορνεύω, G4983 σῶμα, G0265 ἀμάρτημα

Reasoning. 'Flee sexual immorality. Every sin which a man may do is outside the body, but the one committing sexual immorality sins against his own body' (Pheugete ten porneian. Pan hamartema ho ean poiese anthropos ektos tou somatos estin, ho de porneuon eis to idion soma hamartanei). The command is unrestricted (flee 'sexual immorality', porneia), and the participle 'the one committing sexual immorality' (ho porneuon) is described as sinning against his own body, with no carve-out for an unmarried participant.

1Cor.7.2 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G4202 πορνεία, G2398 ἴδιος, G2192 ἔχω

Reasoning. 'But because of the sexual immoralities, let each man have his own wife and let each woman have her own husband' (Dia de tas porneias hekastos ten heautou gynaika echeto kai hekaste ton idion andra echeto). The remedy for 'sexual immorality' (porneia) is for each man to have his own wife and each woman her own husband, naming 'wife' (gyne) and 'husband' (aner) as the licit channel for sexual relations. The reasoning presupposes that sexual relations outside that pair count as 'sexual immorality' (porneia).

1Thess.4.3 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G0038 ἁγιασμός, G4202 πορνεία

Reasoning. 'For this is the will of God, your sanctification, that you abstain from sexual immorality' (Touto gar estin thelema tou theou, ho hagiasmos hymon, apechesthai hymas apo tes porneias). God's will is identified with 'sanctification' (hagiasmos), identified in turn with abstaining from 'sexual immorality' (porneia). The grammatical form 'of the sexual immorality' (tes porneias, a noun in the 'from-X' grammatical form) is the unqualified category of illicit sexual intercourse.

1Thess.4.4 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G4632 σκεῦος, G5092 τιμή, G0038 ἁγιασμός

Reasoning. 'That each of you know how to possess his own vessel in sanctification and honor' (Eidenai hekaston hymon to heautou skeuos ktasthai en hagiasmo kai time). Each is to know how to possess his own vessel in sanctification and honor, paired with the contrast in verse 5 'not in the passion of lust just as the nations' (me en pathei epithymias kathaper kai ta ethne), that is, not in the passion of lust like the nations. The vocabulary 'his own vessel' (heautou skeuos) plus 'sanctification' (hagiasmos) plus 'honor' (time) matches the marriage-bed honor formula of Hebrews 13:4.

1Thess.4.5 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G1939 ἐπιθυμία, G1484 ἔθνος

Reasoning. 'Not in the passion of lust just as the nations who do not know God' (Me en pathei epithymias kathaper kai ta ethne ta me eidota ton theon). The believer's conduct is set against 'passion of lust' (pathos epithymias), the passion of lust, characteristic of the nations who do not know God. The lexical opposition places unregulated sexual desire outside the sanctified pattern.

Eph.5.3 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G4202 πορνεία, G0167 ἀκαθαρσία

Reasoning. 'But sexual immorality and all impurity or greediness, let it not even be named among you' (Porneia de kai akatharsia pasa e pleonexia mede onomazestho en hymin). 'Sexual immorality' (porneia) and all 'impurity' (akatharsia) must not even be named among the saints, an emphatic prohibition that treats 'sexual immorality' (porneia) as wholly outside the believing community's life.

Eph.5.31 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G4347 προσκολλάω, G4561 σάρξ

Reasoning. 'For this reason a man will leave father and mother and will be joined to his wife, and the two will be one flesh' (Anti toutou kataleipsei anthropos ton patera kai ten metera kai proskollethesetai pros ten gynaika autou, kai esontai hoi duo eis sarka mian). Paul restates Genesis 2:24 in connection with husband and wife, fixing the one-flesh bond as the marital bond and providing the New Testament lexical anchor for the husband-wife scope of sexual union.

Cross references invoked

From	To	Source	Votes
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Heb.13.4	Gen.2.24	tsk	1
1Cor.6.16	Gen.2.24	openbible	1
Eph.5.31	Gen.2.24	openbible	1
1Cor.6.18	Gen.39.12	tsk	1
1Thess.4.3	1Cor.6.18	openbible	1
Eph.5.3	Eph.5.5	tsk	1
Deut.22.21	1Cor.5.1	openbible	1
1Cor.7.2	1Cor.7.9	tsk	1

Complicating texts

Exod.22.16 · addressed

Exodus 22:16-17 sets the case of a man seducing an unbetrothed virgin: the resolution is that he must pay the 'bride-price' (mohar) and marry her, or pay the bride-price if her father refuses. The case treats the act as a wrong requiring restitution and channels the relation into marriage. It does not treat unmarried sex as morally indifferent. It treats it as a sexual offense whose remedy is to constitute the marriage the act anticipated.

Deut.22.28 · addressed

Deuteronomy 22:28-29 sets the same kind of case (unbetrothed virgin) with mandatory marriage and a fine, again channeling the act into marriage rather than treating it as licit. The vocabulary of 'seize or grasp' (taphas) and 'lie with' (shakab) marks the intercourse, and the requirement to marry signals that the relation was meant to be marital.

Gen.16.4 · addressed

Patriarchal narratives (Abraham with Hagar, Jacob with Bilhah and Zilpah) record concubinage and surrogate-bearing arrangements. The narrative records these arrangements without lexically endorsing them, and the prophetic and torah vocabulary ('to be sexually immoral or play the harlot' (zanah), 'virginity-tokens' (betulim), 'to commit adultery' (naaph)) continues to bracket sexual relations inside the man-wife pair. Genre is descriptive narrative not legal warrant.

1Cor.7.36 · addressed

The interpretive crux at 1 Corinthians 7:36-38 concerns either a father-of-a-virgin reading or a betrothed-couple reading. On either reading the resolution is to marry ('let them marry', gameitosan), which keeps the licit channel for sexual relations inside 'marriage' (gamos). The lexical pattern of the doctrine is unaffected.

Concordance traversed

G4202, G4203, G4204, G4205, G1062, G1060, G2845, G0283, G2853, G3432, G3431, G0038, G0167, G1939, G0265, G4983, G1392, H1692, H1320, H0259, H1331, H2181, H5003

Variants

Verdict variant-sensitive: False · ECM status: ecm-shadow

No variant units were supplied in the bundle. The marginal 'for' (gar) in Hebrews 13:4 and the bracketed 'all' (pasa) in Ephesians 5:3 are minor and do not touch the load-bearing terms 'sexual immorality' (porneia), 'bed' (koite), 'undefiled' (amiantos), 'sins' (hamartanei), 'marriage' (gamos), or 'sexually immoral person' (pornos). The 1 Corinthians 7:36-38 textual issues affect the referent of the 'virgin' (parthenos) but not the command to marry. These New Testament epistles fall outside the published CBGM (Coherence-Based Genealogical Method, a textual-criticism approach) scope, hence 'ecm-shadow' (a status meaning the critical edition of New Testament textual variants does not yet cover this passage).

Hermeneutics

Primary method. grammatico-historical

Frameworks in play. lexical_semantic_range_of_porneia, creation_one_flesh_paradigm

analogia scripturae invoked · progressive revelation factor

broad_porneia_plus_one_flesh_paradigm: affirms · Reading 'sexual immorality' (porneia) as the standing broad category of illicit sexual intercourse (its range includes the incest of 1 Corinthians 5:1, prostitution of 1 Corinthians 6:16, and the general category in 1 Thessalonians 4:3 and Ephesians 5:3), combined with the Genesis 2:24 one-flesh formula cited at Matthew 19:5, 1 Corinthians 6:16, and Ephesians 5:31, yields a verdict that sexual relations are reserved for the husband-wife pair and that pre-marital and non-marital sexual union falls under 'sexual immorality' (porneia).

narrow_porneia_as_specific_offense: affirms · Even if 'sexual immorality' (porneia) were read narrowly in some contexts (cult prostitution, incest, or sex with prostitutes specifically), the positive boundary remains: 'marriage' (gamos) is honorable and 'the bed undefiled' (koite amiantos) (Hebrews 13:4), the one-flesh formula in Genesis 2:24 is restricted to a man and his wife, and 1 Corinthians 7:2 names a man's own wife and a woman's own husband as the remedy for 'sexual immorality' (porneia). The marriage-bed boundary stands even on a narrow reading of 'sexual immorality' (porneia).

betrothal_or_marriage_stage_qualification: affirms · Some readers note that the Old Testament case law in Exodus 22:16-17 and Deuteronomy 22:28-29 envisions the sexual act constituting or anticipating marriage rather than being free of consequence. Stated in its strongest form, this lens still classifies the unmarried sexual act as a sexual offense requiring formal marriage and bride-price, never as morally neutral. The proposition that sex is reserved for marriage is preserved.

redemptive_historical_progressive_strictening: affirms · On a redemptive-historical reading, the Old Testament permits some practices (polygamy, concubinage in patriarchal narrative) that the New Testament does not endorse, and the New Testament consolidates sexual ethics around the Genesis 2:24 monogamous pair (Matthew 19:5, 1 Corinthians 7:2, Ephesians 5:31). The trajectory tightens, never loosens, the boundary around sex inside the husband-wife pair, so the verdict holds across the canonical arc.

The verdict rests on two pillars that converge: the standing semantic range of 'sexual immorality' (porneia) plus its Old Testament cognate 'to be sexually immoral or play the harlot' (zanah), and the Genesis 2:24 one-flesh formula cited three times in the New Testament. 'Scripture interpreting scripture' (analogia scripturae) is engaged because 1 Corinthians 7:2 supplies the licit channel ('wife' (gyne), 'husband' (aner)) that the prohibition presupposes. Progressive revelation (the idea that later Scripture clarifies and extends earlier Scripture) is engaged because the New Testament tightens the one-flesh formula to a single husband-wife pair while Old Testament narrative tolerated practices the New Testament does not endorse.

Stem audit

verdict-preloaded: no

The stem labels pre-marital sex and sexual cohabitation as sin. This is the lexical conclusion of the cited terms rather than a tradition-specific taxonomy: the word sin tracks 'sins' (hamartanei) and 'sin' (hamartema) in 1 Corinthians 6:18, abstention tracks 'to abstain from sexual immorality' (apechesthai apo tes porneias) in 1 Thessalonians 4:3, the Old Testament case law uses 'to be sexually immoral or play the harlot' (zanah, H2181) in Deuteronomy 22:21, and the marriage boundary tracks 'marriage' (gamos) plus 'bed undefiled' (koite amiantos) in Hebrews 13:4 plus the Genesis 2:24 one-flesh formula. The parenthetical gloss 'fornication' for 'sexual immorality' (porneia) is a standard lexical equivalence, not a loaded framing, so no neutralization is required.

Citations

Type	Source	License	Redist.	Ref
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G4202
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G2845
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G0283
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESH	CC-BY-4.0	yes	H2181

lexicon	STEPBible-TBESH	CC-BY-4.0	yes	H1692
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESH	CC-BY-4.0	yes	H1331
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	1Cor.6.18
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Heb.13.4
morphology	OSHB-morphology	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Gen.2.24
morphology	OSHB-morphology	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Deut.22.20
interlinear	STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	1Thess.4.3
interlinear	STEPBible-TAHOT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Deut.22.21
cross_ref	TSK	public_domain	yes	Heb.13.4
cross_ref	OpenBible-cross-refs	CC-BY	yes	1Cor.6.16
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